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Consider This Before You Buy Leads Online



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer
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Why go through the work of organically generating leads when you can just purchase leads online? The concept sounds enticing. For a few bucks you could have a large list of fresh leads. But are they fresh? When you buy leads online, is it worth the cost and the risk compared to organically generating your own?

Lead Generation vs. Purchasing Leads Online

There are many enthusiastic supporters of purchasing leads online. However, those supporters seem to have become less vocal than those who speak out against buying leads online.

Realtors have a constant need for fresh leads. Purchasing leads online might make casting a wide net for potential conversion easier. But this can become costly and eat into your bottom line quickly.

Brian Talley is the broker-owner of Regent Property Group. In a [May 2013](#) interview with Realtor Magazine, he said, "Honestly, the cost of purchasing online leads is still higher for me than I'd like." Talley adds, "I don't do that anymore. Instead I focus more on my efforts to increase the rankings of my main website without PPC campaigns."

Purchasing leads online also tends to net you discarded, old or used leads that another company found no luck with. This is compounded by the fact that you would be contacting people who have shown no initial interest in your product or service.



Organic lead generation presents visitors with compelling reasons to want and trust your brand. When you generate organic leads, you allow visitors to opt in. That will probably establish a stronger connection than you'd get from merely buying their contact information and sending them unsolicited emails.

Certain companies, such as [EquiLeads](#), openly sell old leads at a discount to those who purchase leads online. The site reads, "All of the leads iin [sic] our Cherry pick system are sold up to 3 times. If a lead is not sold in one price bracket as it ages it drops in price." To some, this may sound like something to avoid. To others, it may seem like a challenge for the lead purchaser, who must use his sales skills to turn an aged lead into a new customer.

CAN-SPAM and Marketing Lists

The danger of buying leads online includes running afoul of the CAN-SPAM Act of 2003. "Once people have told you they don't want to receive more messages from you, you can't sell or transfer their email addresses, even in the form of a mailing list," the [FTC's CAN-SPAM compliance guide](#) reads.

Even if you unwittingly purchase a lead who wishes not to be contacted, and you do contact that lead, you may receive a costly fine. The FTC notes, "Each separate email in violation of the CAN-SPAM Act is subject to penalties of up to \$16,000."

Since you would most likely purchase leads in bulk, you may unwittingly rack up numerous FTC fines. The cheap leads you can find online may lead to a serious expense in an instant.



Because of CAN-SPAM regulations, companies such as [Experian](#) avoid selling email addresses in their marketing list packages.

There are hundreds of other sites that will sell you leads that include email addresses. However, the Internet marketing community appears to have discovered that the quality, exclusivity and freshness of the leads are often exaggerated to increase purchase appeal. Nick, a Warrior Forum member, explains, "90% of leads sold online are recycled junk. [Don't buy from these sources](#). The BEST quality leads are the ones you generate yourself via AdWords, YSM [Yahoo Search Marketing] and Bing."

Investing in Platforms

Instead of buying leads online, you may be better off putting money into your website. Investing in your own site may improve organic lead generation, which means the leads you gather yourself could be significantly cheaper than those you purchase online. You will also likely cultivate a stronger relationship with organic leads than you would with the purchased variety. This means higher conversion rates and trust in your brand.

As [Realtor Sam DeBord](#) says, in the high-cost niche of real estate, each Realtor would need to potentially convert two leads each month just to make back the cost of buying leads online. Both Realtors interviewed by Realtor Mag decided the most cost effective method to accrue leads would be through organic lead generation.

Takeaway

When you buy leads online you may profit from them. But depending on your niche you may need to convert a number of those leads before you begin to see any profits. If you decide to purchase leads online, consider the costs associated with your niche and the laws of the country where you operate. The decision to buy leads online should be weighed against investing in your platforms. Organic lead generation may seem costly, but may ultimately prove to be the better value.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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